Education

En analys från Swedish Subsidiarity

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Here is the English translation of your file:

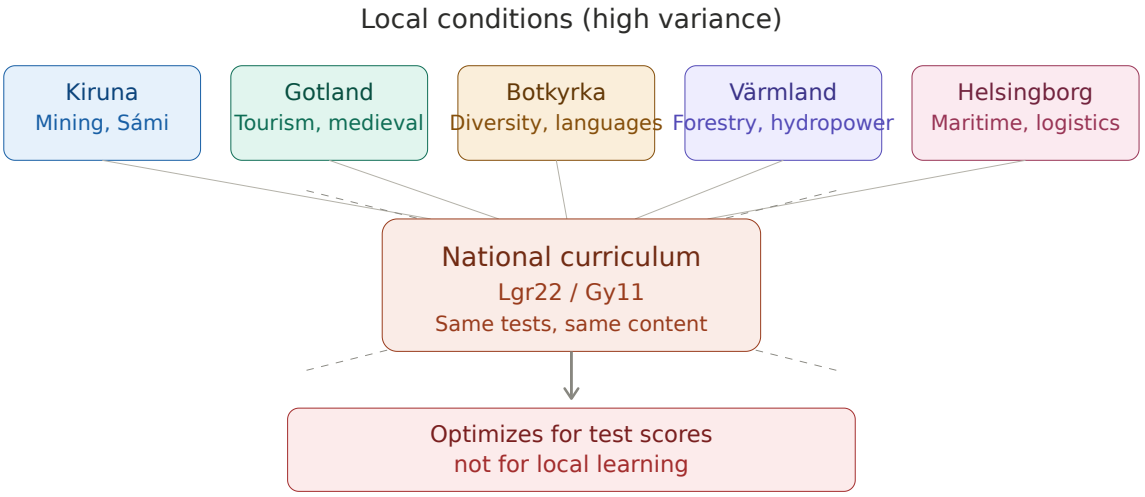
Education: the standardization paradox

The decentralization illusion

Sweden simultaneously has one of Europe's most decentralized education systems (municipal governance, school choice, school vouchers) and one of its most centralized (national tests, standardized curriculum, converging performance metrics). The result: student performance dropped from top-ten globally to below the OECD average after 2000.

The paradox: Nominal decentralization without real autonomy creates the illusion of freedom of choice while forcing uniformity. The system optimizes for measurable standardization (grades, test scores) while the unmeasurable but essential (creativity, critical thinking, practical skills, social integration) is systematically eroded.

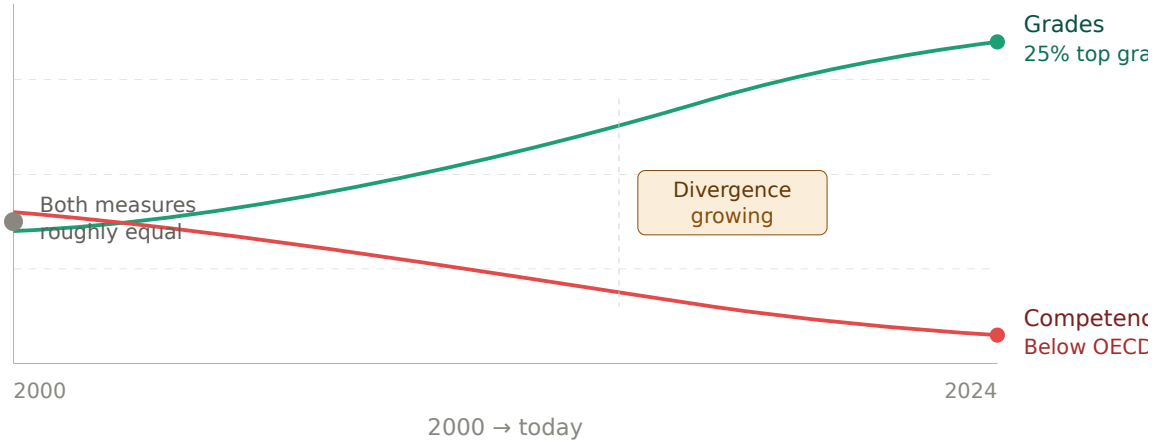
The cybernetic analysis: Learning is fundamentally local, contextual, and relational. An immigrant-dense suburb in Stockholm, a mining town in Norrland, and a tourist community on Gotland face different economic realities, cultural contexts, and student needs. Yet national tests and a uniform curriculum create identical pressure regardless of context. This violates Ashby's law of *requisite variety*: standardized solutions cannot match the diversity of local conditions.



Ashby’s law: uniform solutions cannot match the diversity of Swedish municipalities
40% of teachers leave within 5 years · falling PISA results

Active system failures (in brief)

- **The assessment monoculture**: 25% of students receive top grades while employers report that graduates lack basic skills. The system produces signals (grades) that no longer correlate with substance (competence).
- **The teacher exodus**: 40% of new teachers leave the profession within five years. Teachers become "compliance workers" who implement standardized curricula rather than professionals who adapt to student needs.
- **The certification monopoly**: Formal requirements for teacher certification create barriers to the integration of community expertise. A skilled craftsperson or experienced practitioner is not allowed to teach regardless of their knowledge.
- **The rigidity of the time structure**: School days and academic years follow the patterns of the industrial era—early mornings (despite teenagers' sleep needs) and long summer holidays (from the agrarian society).
- **Captured by digital platforms**: Centralized EdTech procurement creates vendor lock-in that hinders teachers' creativity. Multi-million investments in platforms that optimize for administration, not learning.



Subsidiarity-based measures

Below are five action areas. Each area has its own page with concrete pilots, budgets, rule changes, and analysis of resistance.

Measure	Short description
→ Learning rings	Networks of competence-sharing groups (learning rings) that connect students with local expertise—craftspeople, entrepreneurs, cultural practitioners. Redirects existing association

Measure	Short description
	grants.
→ Municipal curriculum autonomy	Enables municipalities to adapt up to 50% of teaching time to local needs—mining technology in Kiruna, sustainable tourism on Gotland, maritime logistics in Helsingborg.
→ Portfolio-based assessment	Competence portfolios as an alternative to grades—documenting project work, skill demonstrations, peer review, and community contributions. Collaboration with universities and employers.
→ Teacher cooperatives	Teachers organize as cooperatives and write contracts directly with family groups. Increases professional autonomy and compensation, reduces bureaucracy and administrative burden.
→ Competence banks	Digital platform where citizens offer teaching based on demonstrated expertise (without certification). Verification through peer reviews and reputation.

Implementation: from theory to practice

Phase 1 (1–3 years) – Three municipalities (Kiruna, Gotland, Helsingborg) are granted an exemption from 50% of the curriculum requirements to pilot locally adapted methods. Learning rings are financed by redirecting existing association grants. Platform for competence banks is launched.

Phase 2 (3–7 years) – Legal structures for teacher cooperatives are established. Universities pilot portfolio-based admissions alongside grades. After-school centers are developed into makerspaces and skills workshops.

Phase 3 (7–15 years) – Schools transition from closed institutions to coordination hubs for distributed learning (workplaces, cultural institutions, nature). Age-based divisions are replaced by competence-based progression.

Expected resistance and answers

Concern	Response
"Decentralization increases inequality"	The current system already has inequality. Weighted school vouchers provide more resources to vulnerable areas.
"Teacher unions oppose cooperatives"	The current system yields a 40% staff turnover due to burnout. Cooperatives can increase autonomy and meaning.

Concern	Response
"University admissions require grades"	Three pilot universities are testing portfolio-based admissions—creating pathways for recognition.
"Not all municipalities have the same capacity"	Inter-municipal collaboration and shared resources prevent capacity gaps.

The Swedish advantage

Sweden has **independent school precedents** (experience with alternative school forms), **digital infrastructure** (supports platforms), **tradition of popular education** (study associations and adult education), **municipal self-government** (enables pilots), and **high parental engagement**.

Conclusion: choose between standardized tests and real learning

Swedish education demonstrates a fundamental mismatch: applying standardized industrial logic to fundamentally local, contextual learning. The system works exactly as it is designed—it produces measurable credentials while failing to develop genuine competence.

The choice is simple:

- Continue as today: More national tests, more standardization, increased teacher exodus, falling results, growing divides.
- Begin the transition: Learning rings, local curriculum autonomy, portfolio assessment, teacher cooperatives, competence banks.

Three things you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Propose applying for an exemption from the curriculum requirements to pilot locally adapted teaching. Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a teacher or principal: Start a learning ring—invite local craftspeople, entrepreneurs, or retired experts to hold a workshop for students. No grant needed, just initiative.

If you are a parent: Ask your child's school: "How much of the teaching is adapted to our municipality's local business life and culture?" Start a dialogue.

This analysis applies cybernetic principles (Ashby's law of requisite variety) to Swedish education. For deeper measures, click on the links above.

Learning rings

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Summary: Networks of competence-sharing groups (called learning rings) that connect students with expertise in the local community—craftspeople, entrepreneurs, retired engineers, artists, artisan farmers, cultural practitioners. Each learning ring consists of 10–20 students and 3–5 "experts" (knowledgeable individuals) from the community. The group meets 2–4 hours a week, often at a workplace, association premises, or in nature. The goal: to break the monopoly of the standardized curriculum by adding local, practical, and context-bound knowledge that the school cannot offer today. Financing is done by redirecting existing association and leisure grants (about SEK 1,000 per child and year)—no new taxes or large state grants are required.

The mechanism

Today, the school is a closed institution. Students spend thousands of hours in classrooms but rarely encounter the knowledge that exists outside the school walls—how to start a business, repair a car, grow food, build furniture, lead an association, preserve a cultural tradition. At the same time, there is an enormous untapped resource in society: skilled professionals, experienced seniors, newly arrived immigrants with unique skills, entrepreneurs, cultural workers.

The measure: A **learning ring** is a structured but flexible group where:

- 10–20 students (usually from the same school or grade) sign up voluntarily.
- 3–5 "experts" (community experts) are recruited from the local community—a retired civil engineer, a florist, a game designer, a blacksmith, a nurse.
- The group meets during a semester (8–12 sessions) to work on a practical project: building a birdhouse, starting a mini-company, documenting local history, growing vegetables, creating a podcast.
- Each session is led by a teacher or youth recreation leader together with one or more of the experts.
- The students document their learning in a **portfolio** (images, reflections, finished products) that can be used for assessment in school (replacing some traditional teaching).

What the learning ring adds (that the school lacks):

Needs in today's school	The learning ring's solution
Withdrawal from practical knowledge	Tools, materials, work steps – learning by doing
Lack of local role models	Young people meet adults with real professions and passions
Hard to motivate theoretical subjects	Math through carpentry, Swedish through podcasts, biology through farming
Standardized curriculum doesn't suit everyone	Local knowledge becomes part of the teaching

The financing model (the key innovation):

Today, every child in Sweden receives about SEK 1,000 a year in various forms of association grants, leisure grants, culture checks, and municipal activity support. The money is fragmented and often used inefficiently. The proposal: **Redirect SEK 500 per child and year** from these pots to a **learning ring check** that the school can use to pay the experts (fee SEK 200–500 per session), materials, snacks (fika), and venue rental.

This is how the flow looks:

1. The municipality gathers existing funds from various grants (association grants, culture checks, leisure funds) into a common **learning ring pot**.
2. Schools apply for funds to start learning rings (simple digital application, max 5 minutes).
3. Granted learning rings receive a check of SEK 5,000–15,000 per semester (depending on the number of students and sessions).
4. The school uses the money for fees to the experts (SEK 300/hour is a good level), materials, and refreshments.
5. Accounting is done through the portfolio (what the students have learned)—not through bureaucratic receipts.

Pilot design – 50 learning rings first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): 50 learning rings are started in 10–20 municipalities with varying profiles—large city, rural area, high proportion of newly arrived immigrants, high proportion of elderly. Each learning ring comprises 15 students on average.

Selection criteria:

- The municipality commits to gathering existing grants into a learning ring pot (at least SEK 500 per student in the municipality).

- The school appoints a **learning ring coordinator** (teacher or recreation leader) who recruits experts and organizes the meetings.
- The learning ring must be free for the students (no fee) and available to everyone regardless of socio-economic background.

Examples of learning rings in the pilot:

Location	Theme	Experts	Project
Kiruna	Mining technology and Sami handicraft	Retired mining engineer, Sami duodji artisan	Build a model of the mine, make a pewter piece of jewelry
Gotland	Sustainable tourism and Middle Ages	Guide at the Visby city wall, hotel manager, archaeologist	Plan a virtual tour, interview tourists
Rosengård (Malmö)	Entrepreneurship and cooking	Restaurateur with an immigrant background, e-commerce entrepreneur	Start a mini-cafe, cook dishes from different countries
Värmland countryside	Forestry and handicraft	Hunter, artisan, carpenter	Build birdhouses, make a stool, learn to chop wood
Norrköping	Tech and design	Game developer, graphic designer, programmer	Create a simple computer game, design a logo

Evaluation:

- Number of participating students (target: 750 the first year, 2,000 year 3)
- Students' motivation and attendance (compared to regular teaching)
- Learning effect: measurement of specific skills (e.g., math through building projects) compared to a control group
- Teachers' experience of workload and meaningfulness
- Change in collaboration between school and local community

Budget and financing

Item	Amount (per learning ring 15 students, 10 meetings)	Total 50 learning rings
Fee to experts (3 people × 10 meetings × SEK 300)	SEK 9,000	SEK 450,000
Materials (wood, tools, food, printing)	SEK 3,000	SEK 150,000
Fika, venue rental (if needed)	SEK 2,000	SEK 100,000
Learning ring coordinator's time (10 hours planning)	SEK 5,000 (overtime/comp)	SEK 250,000
Total per learning ring	**SEK 19,000**	**SEK 950,000**

Financing: SEK 950,000 for 750 students = approximately SEK 1,270 per student. This is in line with current association and leisure grants (approx. SEK 1,000–1,500 per child). By redirecting existing funds (no new tax), the pilot can be financed entirely within the municipalities' current budgets. For the state: a minor reallocation within the Swedish National Agency for Education's and culture school funds can cover national coordination.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Education Act (2010:800)** – add a section: *"The school may, as a complement to regular teaching, organize learning rings where students carry out practical projects under the guidance of teachers and external knowledge bearers. The learning ring can replace up to 20% of the teaching time in a subject if the goals in the curriculum are met."*

2. **Ordinance on association grants** – municipalities are given the right to merge different grant pots into a learning ring pot without violating earmarking rules.

3. **Exception to the Secrecy Act** – the experts do not need to undergo formal teacher certification, but must be able to show an extract from the criminal record (to protect the students). This is regulated in a simple ordinance.

Expected resistance and answers

"This is handing teaching over to amateurs – teachers are educated for a reason."

Answer: The learning ring is a complement, not a replacement. The teacher is always present and is responsible for connecting the project to the curriculum's goals. The experts contribute their unique expertise – just as the school currently invites guest lecturers. The difference is that it becomes structured and recurring.

"Trade unions will protest – this threatens teachers' jobs."

Answer: On the contrary. Teachers get a more varied workday and can focus on what they are good at: planning, leading, and assessing learning. The experts relieve the burden by providing practical guidance. Several teachers' unions have expressed frustration over the lack of practical elements – the learning ring is a solution, not a threat.

"Municipalities do not have the resources to coordinate this."

Answer: The model is based on reallocation, not new money. And the pilot is small – 50 learning rings require minimal administration. A person at 25% can coordinate an entire municipality. Experiences from municipalities that have already tested similar concepts (e.g., "School-Business Life") show that it works.

"How do you guarantee that the students learn the right things?"

Answer: The teacher is responsible for connecting the project to the curriculum. The portfolio documents what has been learned. And if the learning ring doesn't work – then it is terminated after the semester. No coercion. The risk is minimal compared to the potential: increased motivation, deeper learning, stronger ties between school and society.

"Are there Swedish examples?"

Answer: Yes, several. "School-Business Life" (Swedish Association of Local Authorities and Regions) connects schools with local companies, but it is usually single days. "Workplace Learning" (GY11) involves internships, but rarely with structured knowledge transfers. "Hela Sverige ska leva" (All Sweden Shall Live) runs community center projects with schools. The learning ring gathers these good ideas into a simple, scalable model.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Apprenticeship system (vocational programs)** – already exists, but lacks an equivalent for theoretical programs. The learning ring is a lightweight version.
- **Creative School (Skapande skola)** – state grant for culture in school, but often one-off visits. The learning ring is recurring and integrated.
- **After-school centers' makerspaces** – some after-school centers have workshops, but rarely linked to subject teaching. The learning ring can be integrated.
- **Norway's "The Cultural Schoolbag" (Den kulturelle skolesekken)** – a similar model where artists and artisans work with schools over time. Sweden can copy and broaden this to all types of knowledge bearers.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a teacher or principal: Call a retired professional in your area—a carpenter, a gardener, an entrepreneur—and ask: "Can you come and hold a workshop for my class once a week for a month?" Start on a small scale.

If you are a municipal politician: Submit a proposal to allocate SEK 100,000 for a pilot with 5 learning rings in your municipality. Use the text above as a basis. Show that the money can be taken from existing association grants.

If you are a professional (retiree, craftsperson, artist, engineer): Contact your local school. Tell them what you can teach. Offer to be an "expert" in a learning ring. Even a few hours a month makes a big difference.

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Municipal curriculum autonomy

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Summary: Enables municipalities to adapt up to 50% of teaching time to local needs, while national standards for basic competencies (reading, writing, arithmetic) are maintained. Each municipality develops a **local curriculum profile** that reflects the local business sector, cultural characteristics, geographical conditions, and student composition. Example: Kiruna can focus on mining technology and Sami culture, Gotland on sustainable tourism and medieval history, Helsingborg on maritime logistics and international trade. The goal: to replace today's one-size-fits-all solution with a flexible structure that follows Ashby's law—local variation requires local adaptation.

The mechanism

Today, the Swedish curriculum (Lgr22, Gy11) is nationally uniform. A school in Kiruna and a school in Malmö are expected to cover the same content, in the same order, with the same timetable. Exceptions exist (e.g., mother tongue instruction, local additions), but they are marginal (max 10–15% of the time). This is despite the fact that the students' future labor market, cultural frames of reference, and societal challenges look completely different.

The measure: Introduce **municipal curriculum profiles** where:

- Parliament establishes a **national core** (50% of teaching time) that covers basic competencies: Swedish, mathematics, English, civics, and basic natural sciences.
- The municipalities design a **local profile** (30% of the time) that reflects local needs. Examples of content: local business sector, cultural heritage, languages, entrepreneurship, environment, technology.
- The schools (or individual teachers) are given additional **individual flexibility** (20% of the time) to adapt to the students' interests and needs (e.g., in-depth studies, project work, internships).

What the local profile can contain (concrete examples):

Municipality	Business profile	Cultural profile	Geographical profile
Kiruna	Mining technology, mountain safety, remote control of machines	Sami duodji, yoik, reindeer husbandry, Meänkieli (Tornedalian)	Arctic ecology, permafrost, space research (Esrange)

Municipality	Business profile	Cultural profile	Geographical profile
Gotland	Sustainable tourism, event planning, hospitality industry	Medieval Week, Gotlandic churches, limestone craftsmanship	Baltic Sea ecology, coastal farming, wind power
Helsingborg	Maritime logistics, international trade, port operations	Oresund region, cross-border collaboration	Marine biology, urban development in Oresund
Värmland	Forestry, paper pulp, renewable energy	Storytelling tradition (Selma Lagerlöf), Värmlandic dialect	Forest ecology, hydropower, wild reindeer
Botkyrka	Social entrepreneurship, diversity entrepreneurship	Language immersion (Arabic, Somali, Spanish), suburban culture	Urban agriculture, recycling, environmental technology

How it works in practice:

1. The municipal council appoints a **curriculum committee** with teachers, principals, business representatives, cultural creators, students, and parents.
2. The committee produces a proposal for a local profile (goals, content, time allocation) within the framework of the national core.
3. The Swedish National Agency for Education quality-assures that the profile does not violate national minimum requirements (e.g., that Swedish or mathematics are not removed).
4. The Swedish Schools Inspectorate follows up that the profile is implemented and that students reach the knowledge goals.
5. After 4 years, the profile is evaluated nationally—successful profiles can be spread, unsuccessful ones dismantled.

The cybernetic point: Today's uniform curriculum violates Ashby's law—it has too low variation to match Sweden's different municipalities. Municipal profiling increases variation (higher "variety") and thus the system's ability to adapt to the local context.

Pilot design – 5 municipalities first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-5): Five municipalities representing different parts of Sweden are granted an exemption from 50% of the curriculum requirements to develop and test local profiles.

Proposed pilot municipalities (according to the examples above):

1. **Kiruna** – sparsely populated area, Sami culture, mining industry, space technology
2. **Gotland** – island community, tourism, medieval history, coastal ecology

3. **Helsingborg** – big city, logistics, international trade, Oresund
4. **Värmland** – forest region, paper industry, storytelling tradition
5. **Botkyrka** – diversity, suburb, social entrepreneurship, urban agriculture

Process for each pilot municipality:

- Year 1: The municipality forms a curriculum committee and produces a proposal for a local profile.
- Year 2: The Swedish National Agency for Education approves the profile (adjustments may be required). Preparations in the schools (teacher training, materials).
- Years 3–4: Implementation in all schools in the municipality (or a selection of schools). Data collection (student results, motivation, teacher experience).
- Year 5: Evaluation and report. Decision on continuation or national scale-up.

Evaluation criteria:

- National test results in the core subjects (Swedish, mathematics, English)—must not deteriorate compared to control municipalities.
- Students' motivation and attendance (measured with surveys, less unexcused absence).
- Transition to work or higher education (proportion who have a job or are studying within 6 months after upper secondary school).
- Employers' satisfaction (survey to local companies about new employees' competence).
- Teachers' experience of autonomy and job satisfaction (rating scale).

Budget and financing

Item	Amount (per pilot municipality)	Total 5 municipalities
Curriculum committee (20 people × 10 meetings × fee SEK 2,000)	SEK 400,000	SEK 2,000,000
Teacher training (2 days × 500 teachers × SEK 1,500/day)	SEK 1,500,000	SEK 7,500,000
Development of local teaching materials (digital, open)	SEK 500,000	SEK 2,500,000
Evaluation (researchers, data collection, report)	SEK 800,000	SEK 4,000,000
Administration and coordination	SEK 300,000	SEK 1,500,000
Total per municipality	**SEK 3,500,000**	**SEK 17,500,000**

Financing: SEK 17.5 million over 5 years = SEK 3.5 million per year. This is less than 0.01% of the school budget (approx. SEK 300 billion/year). The money can be taken from the Swedish National Agency for Education's development funds or the state grant for equitable schooling. Socio-economically: if the pilots lead to a better match between education and the labor market (lower unemployment, higher productivity), the investment is self-financing many times over.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Education Act (2010:800)** – add a new section: *"The government may, upon application, grant a municipality an exemption from the regulations concerning the curriculum's timetable to test a local curriculum profile. The exemption may cover a maximum of 50% of the teaching time. National knowledge requirements in Swedish, mathematics, and English must always be met."*
2. **Amendment to the Upper Secondary School Ordinance (2010:2039)** – corresponding exemptions for the upper secondary school's program structure.
3. **Ordinance on a national core** – the government determines which subjects and knowledge requirements must always be included (minimum level). The remaining time is flexible.
4. **The Swedish National Agency for Education's regulations** – adjusted so that municipal profiles can be approved in a simple, transparent process (max 6 months processing time).

Expected resistance and answers

"This threatens equivalence—students in different municipalities get different knowledge."

Answer: Equivalence is not about identical content, but about equal opportunities. A student in Kiruna today has worse opportunities to learn mining technology or Sami culture than a student in Stockholm—even though this knowledge is highly relevant to Kiruna's labor market. The national core guarantees basic competencies. The local profile provides actual equivalence—the opportunity to learn what is relevant in one's context.

"The Swedish National Agency for Education will say no—they are conservative."

Answer: Therefore, political governance is required. The government can task the Swedish National Agency for Education with developing a process for municipal profiles. And the pilots are voluntary—no one is forced. When the Swedish National Agency for Education sees that results do not deteriorate (on the contrary, motivation increases), the resistance will decrease. Experiences from Finnish equivalents (local curricula since 2004) show that central authorities can adapt.

"Teachers already have too much to do—developing local profiles will be a new administrative burden."

Answer: The curriculum profile is developed by a committee with allocated time (not unpaid evening work). The municipality can hire a curriculum strategist. And once the profile is developed, the administrative burden for teachers decreases—they do not have to adapt a Stockholm-centered curriculum to local conditions. It is extra work initially, but long-term relief.

"What happens if a municipality makes a bad profile—the students will suffer?"

Answer: The pilot has clear quality requirements and evaluation. If a profile does not work (deteriorated results in core subjects, low goal attainment), the exemption is revoked. The risk is small—municipalities have an incentive to do a good job. And today's one-size-fits-all solution is already bad for many municipalities—the status quo is not risk-free.

"Are there international examples?"

Answer: Yes, several. **Finland** has national curriculum foundations (like our national core) and municipal curricula that specify local priorities—this has worked since 2004. **Norway** has a similar model. **Canada** (the provinces) has large local variation. Sweden is unusually centralized compared to its Nordic neighbors. We are lagging behind—it is time to follow suit.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Local work plans** (existed before 1994) – municipalities previously had greater freedom. Reintroduce in a modern form.
- **Mother tongue instruction** – already an example of local adaptation today (the municipality decides which languages are offered). The scale model exists.
- **National minority languages** – schools in Sami administrative areas already have an expanded mission. Can be extended to other local profiles.
- **Finnish municipal curricula** – each Finnish municipality has its own curriculum within the framework of national foundations. Sweden can copy the organization.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a municipal politician: Submit a proposal that the municipality should apply for pilot status for a local curriculum profile. Gather broad political support (all parties win on local adaptation). Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a teacher or principal: Start a discussion at your school: "What would we do differently if we got to decide 50% of the time?" Gather ideas. Send them to your municipal executive board.

If you are a business or cultural representative: Contact the municipality and offer to participate in a curriculum committee. Explain what competencies are in demand in your industry. Make your voice heard.

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Portfolio-based assessment

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Summary: Competence portfolios as an alternative or complement to traditional grades. Students document project work, skill demonstrations, peer reviews, and community contributions in a digital portfolio. The assessment is done by teachers together with external reviewers (from working life or higher education) and focuses on actual ability, not on test results. The goal: to measure what matters—creativity, problem-solving, collaboration, practical wisdom—which today's standardized grades miss. Three universities are piloting the portfolio as a basis for admission alongside merit rating.

The mechanism

Today, almost all assessment in Swedish schools is based on written tests and assignments graded by the teacher. The grade is a synthesis of these results. The system optimizes for the ability to write tests under time pressure—not for the ability to solve real problems, collaborate in teams, or create something of value.

The measure: Introduce **portfolio-based assessment** as an equal path to grades and admission:

- Every student builds a **digital portfolio** throughout their school years (from grade 7 to upper secondary school graduation).
- The portfolio contains:
  - *Project work*: documentation of longer assignments (e.g., starting a mini-company, building a model, conducting an investigation).
  - *Skill demonstrations*: video clips, images, audio recordings where the student demonstrates a practical skill (e.g., giving an oral presentation, solving a technical task, cooking a meal).
  - *Peer reviews*: written assessments from other students about collaboration skills and contributions to group work.
  - *Community contributions*: documentation of involvement in associations, volunteer work, internships, entrepreneurship.
  - *Self-reflections*: students regularly write about their own learning, their strengths, and areas for development.
- The assessment is made by:
  - **The teacher** (60% of the weight) – assesses subject knowledge and progression.
  - **External reviewers** (30%) – representatives from working life or higher education who assess relevance and quality.

    - **Peers** (10%) – assess collaboration and group dynamics (anonymized).
- The portfolio is supplemented with **national tests** in the core subjects (to ensure equivalence and calibration), but the test result is just one factor among several.

What the portfolio measures that grades miss:

Dimension	Grades	Portfolio
Creativity	Hard to measure	Documented through projects and original solutions
Real-world problem solving	Abstract	Shown through practical demonstrations
Collaboration skills	Invisible	Peer reviews and group documentation
Perseverance	Not at all	Long projects show the ability to follow through
Communication skills	Written (test)	Oral, visual, written in different contexts
Ethical judgment	Not at all	Reflections on one's own and others' actions

Pilot design – 10 schools and 3 universities first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-4): 10 compulsory and upper secondary schools (varying in size, geography, socio-economics) test portfolio-based assessment instead of or alongside grades. Three universities (e.g., Uppsala, Lund, Umeå) commit to testing portfolios as a basis for admission to at least 5 educational programs.

Selection criteria for schools:

- The school has a digital infrastructure (computers, platform) that enables portfolio work.
- The teachers are interested and receive training (40 hours) in portfolio-based assessment.
- The school commits to following the pilot's guidelines and participating in evaluation.

Organizational model:

- Each school appoints a **portfolio coordinator** (0.2 FTE) responsible for implementation, technical support, and calibration between teachers.
- The teachers in the pilot receive halved teaching time to manage assessment and tutoring (portfolios are more time-consuming than grading tests, but provide a better basis).
- An **external reviewer pool** is established in collaboration with the Confederation of Swedish Enterprise (Svenskt Näringsliv), trade unions, and universities. The reviewers receive 40 hours of training and a fee per assessment.

- A **digital platform** (open source) is developed to store, share, and assess portfolios. The platform supports video uploads, peer review, and external access.

The admission process at universities:

- Applicants who want to use a portfolio instead of (or to complement) grades apply as usual via antagning.se.
- The portfolio is assessed by two independent reviewers (from subject-relevant departments or working life) according to a transparent matrix.
- Grades from national tests are used as calibration (to avoid portfolios from "easy" schools being unfairly favored).
- After the pilot, an evaluation is made on whether portfolio-based students cope with the studies as well as or better than students admitted on grades.

Evaluation:

- Compare students in pilot schools with matched control schools (traditional grades).
- Efficacy measures: motivation (survey scale), attendance, completion rate, transition to work/studies.
- The universities measure: dropout rate after the first semester, study results, perceived preparation.
- Cost comparison: portfolio assessment vs. traditional tests and grades (teacher time, administration).

Budget and financing

Item	Amount (10 schools + 3 universities)
Platform (development, operation, support)	SEK 2,000,000 (one-time)
Teacher training (40 hrs × 100 teachers × SEK 500/hr)	SEK 2,000,000 (one-time)
Portfolio coordinators (10 × 0.2 FTE × SEK 500,000/year)	SEK 1,000,000/year
Reduced teaching time (100 teachers × 10 hrs/week × 35 weeks × SEK 400/hr)	SEK 14,000,000/year
External reviewer pool (fee per assessment, estimated 1,000 students × 2 reviewers × SEK 1,000)	SEK 2,000,000/year
Evaluation (researchers, data collection)	SEK 1,500,000/year
Total first year	**SEK 22.5 million**
Annual operation after scale-up	**SEK 18.5 million** (excl. one-time)

Financing: SEK 22.5 million is a very small proportion of the school budget (300 billion). The funds can be taken from the Swedish National Agency for Education's development funds and state grants for digitalization. The universities' costs for admission (approximately SEK 50,000 per educational program) can be accommodated within their regular budgets.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the School Ordinance (2011:185)** – add a section: *"Assessment of the student's knowledge may, in addition to tests and grades, take place through portfolio-based assessment in accordance with regulations from the National Agency for Education. The portfolio can form the basis for grading in one or more subjects."*
2. **Amendment to the Higher Education Ordinance (1993:100)** – add: *"When admitting to basic education, a higher education institution may, in addition to grades and the Swedish Scholastic Aptitude Test (högskoleprovet), also use competence portfolios as a basis for assessment. The government may grant exceptions for pilot activities."*
3. **The National Agency for Education's general guidelines** – a new section on portfolio assessment with guidelines for calibration, external review, and quality assurance.
4. **GDPR adaptation** – portfolios contain personal data (image, video). Consent from the student/guardian is required, as well as technical solutions for storage and deletion. Simple templates are produced.

Expected resistance and answers

"Portfolios are subjective – grades are objective."

Answer: Grades are far from objective. Research shows great variation between teachers and schools (the same performance can get different grades). The portfolio reduces subjectivity through external review, peer assessment, and clear matrices. It is more legally secure than today's system.

"It will be too much work for the teachers."

Answer: Portfolio assessment requires more time per student, but fewer tests and less grading. In the pilot, teachers get reduced teaching time (10 hrs/week) to compensate. If the portfolio leads to deeper learning and higher motivation, it may be worth the investment. The alternative is today's system with a 40% teacher flight—that is unsustainable.

"Universities won't accept portfolios – they want numbers."

Answer: University admission is regulated in the Higher Education Ordinance, which currently only allows grades, the Swedish Scholastic Aptitude Test, and in some cases work samples or interviews. In order for portfolios to be used, a legislative amendment or a government decision on pilot exemptions is required. The pilot's purpose is precisely to create the basis needed to convince the government and universities that portfolios work. Research from other countries (e.g., USA, Canada) shows that portfolios can predict study success as well as or better than grades—but Swedish evidence is currently lacking.

"Students from under-resourced homes will not benefit – they can't afford coaches who build nice portfolios."

Answer: The portfolio is built during school hours, using the school's digital tools and teacher guidance. External coaches are not allowed. Reviewers are trained to see through "polished surfaces" and assess actual knowledge. On the contrary, the portfolio can benefit students who are not good at taking tests but have other strengths—often from under-resourced homes.

"Are there international examples?"

Answer: Yes. The **USA** has "portfolio-based assessment" in many schools and districts (e.g., New York Performance Standards Consortium). **Canada** (British Columbia) uses portfolios as part of the graduation exam. The **UK** has "coursework" which is similar to a portfolio, but often less comprehensive. **Finland** is testing portfolios in some schools. Sweden can become best in class.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **The upper secondary school diploma project (Gymnasiearbetet)** – already a form of portfolio, but only for one subject and often weakly integrated. The scale model exists.
- **Digital student portfolios** (e.g., Schoolsoft, Google Classroom) – many schools already use digital tools to collect student work. Our model utilizes existing infrastructure.
- **The Swedish Scholastic Aptitude Test (Högskoleprovet)** – a complement to grades. The portfolio becomes a third leg.
- **Norway's "eksamen med mappevurdering" (exam with portfolio assessment)** – Norway has portfolio assessment in several subjects. Sweden can copy and improve.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a teacher or principal: Test on a small scale—ask students to create a simple portfolio (e.g., in Google Drive) for a project. Have them include peer feedback and self-reflection. Use the portfolio as a basis

for grades instead of a test. Evaluate how it felt.

If you are a university teacher or director of studies: Contact your department board and propose a pilot with portfolio admission to a program with high application pressure. Collaborate with an upper secondary school. Show that it's possible.

If you are a student or parent: Ask your school: "Can we use a portfolio instead of some tests? I would like to show what I know in other ways." The more people who ask, the harder it is to ignore.

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Teacher cooperatives

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Summary: Teachers organize as cooperative enterprises rather than as municipal employees. The cooperative signs an agreement directly with a group of guardians (at least 50 families) or with a municipality to run a school or part of a school's operations. The teachers own and govern the cooperative together (one member, one vote), share the surplus, and have full control over pedagogy, schedules, and work distribution. The goal: to increase teachers' professional autonomy, improve compensation (by cutting administrative middlemen), and reduce teacher flight. The model is based on existing legislation on independent schools (Education Act, Chapter 24) but is adapted to favor teacher-owned cooperatives over commercial companies.

The mechanism

Today, the vast majority of teachers are employed by municipalities (or in some cases by independent school corporations). Salaries, working hours, schedules, and pedagogical methods are governed by central agreements and political decisions. Teachers have little influence over their own working situation—even though they are highly educated professionals. The result: 40% quit within five years.

The measure: Introduce **teacher cooperatives** as a new legal and organizational form to run school operations.

- **How a cooperative is formed**: At least 5 certified teachers join forces and form an economic association (cooperative) according to the Economic Associations Act (1987:667).
- **How it is financed**: The cooperative signs an agreement with a municipality (or directly with guardians) to provide education for a certain group of students. The school voucher (approx. SEK 70,000–120,000 per student and year) goes directly to the cooperative.
- **How salaries are set**: The teachers are co-owners and employees of the cooperative. They jointly decide on salary levels (often higher than municipal teachers, since middlemen and administrative overhead are cut). The surplus is reinvested in the operations or distributed as a bonus.
- **How quality is ensured**: The cooperative must follow the same curriculum, the same Education Act, and the same inspection as all other schools. Guardians can opt out of the cooperative if they are dissatisfied (the school choice remains).
- **Difference from existing independent schools**: Today, most independent schools are run by profit-driven companies (often owned by private equity firms). Teacher cooperatives are **non-profit-**

maximizing—any surplus goes to the teachers or back into the operations, not to external owners.

Advantages compared to municipal employment:

Aspect	Municipal school	Teacher cooperative
Decisions on pedagogy	Politicians, officials, principal	The teachers themselves in a democratic process
Workload	Often high, directed from above	Flexible, can be adapted to the assignment
Administrative burden	Documentation for the municipality	Documentation for own operations (can be streamlined)
Salary	Fixed in central agreement	The cooperative decides (can be higher)
Ownership	None	Joint ownership, share of surplus

Practical example: A group of 8 teachers in a medium-sized city forms a cooperative. They sign an agreement with the municipality to take over the responsibility for an existing school (grades F–6) with 120 students. The school voucher is SEK 90,000 per student → total revenue SEK 10.8 million. The teachers budget for salaries (8 × SEK 550,000 = SEK 4.4 million), premises (SEK 2.5 million), materials (SEK 1 million), and administration (SEK 1 million). SEK 1.9 million remains, which can be used for continuing education, extra resources, or a rebate to the members. Each teacher thus receives the equivalent of a salary of about SEK 700,000—a substantial increase from a municipal salary (approx. SEK 450,000). At the same time, the administrative burden is reduced since there is no need to report to a municipal administration.

Pilot design – 5 cooperatives first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Five teacher cooperatives are started in different parts of the country (different school types and sizes). The state or a foundation offers **start-up loans** (SEK 1–2 million per cooperative) and advice during the first year.

Proposed pilots:

Location	Type	Number of teachers	Number of students	Special profile
Gothenburg	Compulsory school F–6	12	180	Reggio Emilia pedagogy

Location	Type	Number of teachers	Number of students	Special profile
Umeå	Lower secondary 7–9	8	120	Nature and technology profile
Landskrona	Compulsory school F–9	15	240	Bilingualism (Swedish/Arabic)
Falun	Upper secondary special school	6	40	Practical vocational training
Stockholm	Preschool	5	60	Outdoor pedagogy (in the forest)

Steps to form a cooperative in the pilot:

1. **Expression of interest**: At least 5 certified teachers send an expression of interest to a national **support organization for teacher cooperatives** (e.g., the Cooperative Institute or a new foundation).
2. **Business plan**: The group develops a simple business plan: budget, premises, catchment area, pedagogical profile.
3. **Financing**: The support organization grants a start-up loan (interest-free for the first 2 years) of SEK 1–2 million to cover initial costs (consulting, legal, marketing).
4. **Agreement with municipality**: The group negotiates with one or more municipalities to receive school vouchers for a certain group of students. The municipality cannot refuse if the cooperative meets the legal requirements (school choice applies).
5. **Registration**: The cooperative is registered with the Swedish Companies Registration Office (Bolagsverket) and the Swedish Schools Inspectorate (as an independent school). Special exemption rule for the pilot: lower capital requirements (SEK 100,000 instead of SEK 200,000).
6. **Start**: Operations kick off after the summer holidays.

Evaluation:

- Teachers' job satisfaction (rating scale) and retention in the profession after 2 years.
- Teachers' salaries compared to municipal teachers in the same region.
- Students' knowledge results (national tests, grades) compared to control schools (matched).
- Parents' satisfaction (SALAR's user survey).
- The cooperative's finances: does it survive, does it run at a profit/loss?

Budget and financing

Item	Amount (for 5 cooperatives)
Start-up loans (interest-free, SEK 1.5 million on average × 5)	SEK 7.5 million (repaid)
Support organization (advice, training, legal)	SEK 2 million/year
Evaluation (research)	SEK 1.5 million/year
Total first year	**SEK 11 million** (7.5 loans + 3.5 costs)

Financing: The start-up loans can come from the state budget (Ministry of Education) or from a fund (e.g., the Swedish Agency for Economic and Regional Growth, the European Regional Development Fund). The costs for support and evaluation are low (SEK 3.5 million/year) compared to the potential savings if teacher flight decreases (a single teacher who stays an extra year saves society SEK 1–2 million in recruitment and induction costs).

Regulatory changes required

1. **Amendment to the Education Act (2010:800) Chapter 24 on independent schools** – add a section: *"Independent schools run as economic associations where the majority of members are certified teachers active in the school shall be given priority when assessing establishment. The government may grant exemptions from the equity requirement for such cooperatives during a pilot period of at least three years."*

2. **Amendment to the Economic Associations Act (1987:667)** – no obstacle, but clarify that a teacher's employment and membership can be combined.

3. **Ordinance on start-up loans** – the government authorizes an agency (e.g., the Swedish National Agency for Education) to grant interest-free start-up loans to teacher cooperatives in the pilot.

4. **Agreement between cooperative and municipality** – SALAR (Swedish Association of Local Authorities and Regions) develops a standard template for agreements regulating school vouchers, premises, student responsibility, and quality follow-up.

Expected resistance and answers

"The municipalities will say no – they don't want to lose control over the schools."

Answer: School choice already gives parents the right to choose an independent school today. The municipality cannot refuse an independent school that meets the legal requirements. On the contrary: teacher cooperatives can be attractive to the municipality because they are often more cost-effective (less administration) and have lower staff turnover. The municipality can also enter into an agreement where the cooperative runs a municipal school on a contract basis—in this way, the municipality retains ownership but outsources the operations.

"The teachers' unions will object – cooperatives threaten collective agreements."

Answer: The cooperative's teachers can still be affiliated with the union (the Swedish Teachers' Union or the National Union of Teachers in Sweden). The cooperative can sign a collective agreement with the union. Experiences from other industries (e.g., healthcare cooperatives, consulting cooperatives) show that unions can adapt. Furthermore: the unions are concerned about teacher flight. Cooperatives are a possible answer to that crisis.

"It will become an elite operation – only good teachers at attractive schools can start cooperatives."

Answer: The risk exists. Therefore, the pilot is small and carefully evaluated. Support can also be directed to cooperatives in vulnerable areas (higher school vouchers, extra start-up capital). The goal is not to replace all municipal schools with cooperatives, but to create a diverse system where cooperatives are one option among several.

"Teachers don't want to be entrepreneurs – they want to teach."

Answer: In a cooperative, teachers can delegate administration and finance to a hired manager (who does not have to be a teacher). The cooperative can also merge with other cooperatives to share common functions (payroll processing, cleaning, IT). Many teachers are attracted by the opportunity to influence their working situation and share in the surplus. For those who do not want to—municipal employment is still an option.

"Are there Swedish examples?"

Answer: Yes, several small-scale ones. **Montessori schools** are often run as non-profit associations, sometimes with teachers on the board. **Parent cooperatives** (preschools) exist in many municipalities, where

parents hire teachers. But purely teacher-owned cooperatives in compulsory schools are rare. The closest is **"Vittra"**, which was started as a teacher cooperative in the 1990s but later became a limited company. The pilot can revive the idea. Internationally, there are **"teacher cooperatives"** in the USA (e.g., Milwaukee), Spain (Escola Sadako), and Finland. Sweden is lagging behind.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Parent cooperatives (preschools)** – have existed since the 1970s, regulated in the Education Act. The model for collaboration between members exists.
- **Employee-owned companies (e.g., consulting cooperatives)** – within IT, architecture, and journalism, there are cooperatives where the employees own and govern. The experiences are good (higher productivity, lower sick leave).
- **Health and social care cooperatives** – e.g., Vardaga started as a cooperative. Elderly care cooperatives exist in several municipalities. The Swedish National Agency for Education can emulate this structure.
- **Norway's "lærersamarbeid"** – Norway has several schools run as collaborative projects between teachers, without commercial owners. Sweden can visit and learn.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a teacher in a group of at least 5 colleagues: Talk about the idea. Write a joint expression of interest to your municipality and to SALAR. Ask for a meeting to discuss the possibility of starting a cooperative. Use the text above as a basis.

If you are a municipal politician or official: Develop a policy for how the municipality can support teacher cooperatives (e.g., by providing premises at cost price, offering advice, being a constructive contracting party). Raise the issue in the municipal executive board.

If you are a union representative: Investigate how your union relates to cooperatives. Are there obstacles in central agreements? Can a collective agreement be signed with a cooperative? Be a bridge-builder, not a roadblock.

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Competence banks

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Summary: A digital platform (open source) where citizens can offer teaching based on demonstrated expertise rather than formal qualifications. A retired engineer can hold a workshop in physics, a florist can teach flower arrangement, a newly arrived immigrant with agricultural experience can show how to farm in the local climate. Verification is done through peer reviews, reputation, and a simple background check (criminal record extract). Municipalities, schools, associations, and individuals can book the competence bearers for a small fee. The goal: to break the certification monopoly and provide the local, practical knowledge that the standardized school misses – at a low cost.

The mechanism

Today, it is basically impossible for a person without a teaching license to teach in school, even if the person possesses unique expertise. A skilled goldsmith, an experienced structural engineer, a knowledgeable mushroom expert – everyone has knowledge that students would greatly benefit from, but formal requirements prevent them from sharing it. At the same time, the school struggles with motivation, relevance, and its connection to working life.

The measure: A **competence bank** is a digital platform where:

- **Competence bearers** (citizens over 18) create a profile with their skills and experiences. No formal grades are required – they can show a portfolio, work samples, or a video presentation.
- **Verification** is done through:
  - *Peer review*: previous participants rate the competence bearer (1–5 stars) after a completed activity.
  - *Background check*: an extract from the criminal record is required to work with children (just like for sports coaches, field assistants, etc.).
  - *Test period*: new competence bearers can hold a first workshop for free or at a reduced price to build a reputation.
- **Clients** (municipalities, schools, youth centers, libraries, associations, parent groups) can search among profiles and book competence bearers for single occasions (2–4 hours) or longer courses (6–8 sessions).
- **Compensation**: The competence bearer receives a fee (e.g., SEK 300–500/hour). The platform takes a small commission (10%) to cover operation and marketing.

- **Connection to the school**: Teachers can book competence bearers as part of the teaching – e.g., a florist who teaches biology through flowers, a carpenter who teaches mathematics through angles and measurements. The activities are documented in the student's portfolio.

What the competence bank solves:

Problem today	The competence bank's solution
The certification monopoly prevents expertise from reaching the school	Teaching without a license is permitted as a guest intervention
The school lacks connection to local working life	Competence bearers come from real professions
Practical knowledge is valued lowly in the curriculum	Students encounter crafts, farming, and technology in reality
Newly arrived immigrants with cutting-edge expertise cannot use it	The competence bank creates a path into working life (extra income, network)
Under-resourced areas have fewer study visits and guests	A digital platform makes competence available to all municipalities

Examples of competence bearers:

Competence	Background	Possible lesson/workshop
Mathematics in the construction industry	Retired structural engineer	Calculate timber consumption, angles, volumes – on a real construction site
Mycology (mushrooms)	Former mushroom inspector	Species identification, ecology, cooking with mushrooms
Textile crafts	Syrian immigrant woman with traditional embroidery art	Sew your own painting, learn different stitches, cultural background
Programming	Self-taught game developer	Build a simple game in Scratch, guest lecture about the career path
Gardening	Biodynamic grower	Sowing, soil, crop rotation – in the school's allotments

Pilot design – 5 regions first

Pilot phase 1 (years 1-3): Five regions or larger municipalities develop a local competence bank (or share a common platform). The pilots are chosen to represent different parts of Sweden (city, rural area, north, south, high proportion of newly arrived immigrants).

Possible pilot locations:

1. **City of Stockholm** – big city mix, many skilled professionals, test scaling
2. **Jämtland (region)** – sparsely populated area, need to activate the competence of the elderly and newly arrived immigrants
3. **Botkyrka municipality** – high proportion of foreign-born, many with unutilized work experience
4. **Region Västra Götaland** (Rural Network) – focus on crafts and small business owners
5. **Norrbotten** – mining and industrial competence, Sami knowledge

Organizational model:

- The region or municipality finances the development of a simple platform (open source, can be reused by others).
- A **competence broker** (0.5–1 FTE) is responsible for recruiting and quality-assuring competence bearers, as well as marketing the platform to schools and associations.
- The platform uses existing digital infrastructure: BankID for login, Swish for payments, peer review systems similar to Uber or Airbnb.
- Compensation to competence bearers: SEK 400/hour (average). The platform takes SEK 40/hour (10%) for operation and marketing.

Quality assurance:

- The competence bearer must show an extract from the criminal record (to work with children).
- The school or client rates the competence bearer after a completed assignment (1–5 stars, comments). Low ratings lead to suspension.
- The first assignment can be free of charge for the school (subsidized by the pilot budget) to test and build a reputation.
- Insurance: competence bearers are covered by the municipality's/region's liability insurance during the assignment (regulated in contract).

Evaluation:

- Number of active competence bearers and number of bookings per month.
- User satisfaction (schools, teachers, competence bearers) measured in ratings (target: >4.5 out of 5).
- Change in students' motivation (teacher survey) linked to subjects that received visits from the competence bank.

- The proportion of competence bearers with a foreign background or without formal higher education (target: >50% to show that networks outside traditional ones have been reached).
- Cost per lesson hour compared to a regular teacher's hourly cost (approx. SEK 800–1,000). Target: under SEK 500 including platform fee.

Budget and financing

Item	Amount (per pilot region, year 1)	Total 5 regions
Platform development (open source, shared)	SEK 500,000 (one-time, shared)	SEK 500,000
Platform operation (server, support, updates)	SEK 100,000/year	SEK 500,000/year
Competence broker (1 FTE × SEK 600,000)	SEK 600,000/year	SEK 3,000,000/year
Marketing (information campaigns to schools, associations)	SEK 200,000/year	SEK 1,000,000/year
Subsidy of first assignments (500 bookings at SEK 400)	SEK 200,000/year	SEK 1,000,000/year
Evaluation	SEK 200,000/year	SEK 1,000,000/year
Total first year	**SEK 1.8 million per region**	**SEK 9 million** (excl. platform development)
Annual operation after scale-up	**SEK 1.3 million per region**	**SEK 6.5 million**

Financing: SEK 9 million in the first year is a very small investment compared to the school budget (SEK 300 billion) and can be taken from regional development funds (EU funds, the Swedish Agency for Economic and Regional Growth) or state grants for skills supply. If the competence bank in each region facilitates 5,000 hours of teaching per year (at SEK 400/hour), that is SEK 2 million in fees to competence bearers – a direct contribution to the local economy.

Regulatory changes required

1. **Clarification in the Education Act (2010:800)** – no prohibition against bringing in external guest teachers without a license, but a clarification can help: *"The school may engage external knowledge bearers to supplement regular teaching. These do not need to have a teaching license, but must be*

able to show an extract from the criminal record if they work with children." (This is already possible today, but many principals are unsure.)

2. **Secrecy and GDPR** – the platform must comply with the General Data Protection Regulation. Simple user policy (consent from competence bearers and clients). No sensitive personal data is stored.
3. **Ordinance on state grants** – The Swedish National Agency for Education or the Swedish Agency for Economic and Regional Growth is tasked with allocating funds for the start-up of competence banks in regions (according to the pilot model).
4. **The Swedish Tax Agency** – fees to competence bearers (under SEK 10,000 per year) can be paid out without tax deduction if it is a minor side income (similar rules as for sports coaches). Simplify to reduce administration.

Expected resistance and answers

"This undermines the teaching profession – anyone can call themselves a competence bearer."

Answer: The competence bank does not replace the teacher. The teacher remains in the classroom, plans the lesson, and integrates the competence bearer's element into regular teaching. The competence bearer is a guest, just like an author who visits the school or an engineer who gives a lecture. The difference is that the competence bank makes it easy for teachers to find and book relevant guests.

"The union will protest – risk of dumping teachers' salaries."

Answer: The competence bearer's fee (SEK 400/hour) is lower than a teacher's hourly cost (SEK 800–1,000), but the competence bearer has no responsibility for planning, grading, follow-up, or classroom management. It is a specialized supplementary effort, not a replacement. On the contrary, several teachers express frustration that they have to be experts on everything – the competence bank relieves them.

"The quality could be bad – no guarantee that competence bearers can teach."

Answer: Peer reviews and background checks are simpler forms of quality assurance. The school can also request that the competence bearer hold a trial lesson (subsidized). In the worst case, a lesson is less successful – it is a small risk compared to the potential. And the system is self-regulating: competence bearers with low ratings will not get new assignments.

"Municipalities and schools will not use the platform – it's easier to book study visits as usual."

Answer: Today's system for booking guest lecturers is ad hoc – you call someone you know or google. The competence bank offers a uniform interface, a rating system, and easy invoicing. For schools that lack local networks (e.g., in vulnerable areas), it is a lifeline. The pilot will have to show if the demand exists.

"Are there Swedish examples?"

Answer: Yes, several similar initiatives at the experimental stage. **"The City Library's makerspace"** in Malmö books local craftspeople for workshops. **"Building technology in school"** (The Swedish Construction Federation) mediates construction workers to schools, but is not a digital platform. **"Skillshift"** (private actor) matches professionals with schools, but is small. The closest internationally is **"Teach for America"** (but that is teacher training) and **"Outschool"** (USA, digital courses). The competence bank is a Swedish, open, and decentralized model.

Swedish examples to build upon

- **Sports coaches in associations** – every weekend, thousands of volunteer coaches lead children and youth in football, handball, etc., without a teaching license. Works excellently. The same principle can be applied to academic subjects.
- **Pensioner organizations** (SPF, PRO) – many pensioners have unique professional experience and time to share. The competence bank can collaborate with them.
- **Study associations** (ABF, NBV, Sensus) – have long experience in organizing study circles with laypeople as leaders. The model exists.
- **Norway's "Kompetansebanken"** (Vox, now Skills Norway) – similar concept for adult education, but not integrated with the school. Sweden can be inspired.

What you can do tomorrow

If you are a principal or teacher: Take an inventory – what local professionals, pensioners, craftspeople, or newly arrived immigrants could contribute to teaching? Call one up and ask: "Can you come and talk about your job?" No need for a digital platform – start analog.

If you are a regional or municipal politician: Allocate a small sum (SEK 200,000) to hire a competence broker on trial. Ask them to map unutilized competence in the region and match it with schools. Evaluate after one year.

If you are a pensioner or professional: Join a study association or contact your local school directly. Tell them what you can teach. Offer to hold a workshop. You don't need a platform – just the willingness to share.

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